

DEVISING



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This text was compiled on 06/11/2025

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Licensing

A detailed breakdown of this resource's licensing can be found in [Back Matter/Detailed Licensing](#).

1.1: Building a Team

Teamwork is the most important ingredient in theater and is the foundation of devising a production. When you put on a play all of the cards are stacked against you (budget, time, etc.) and it is a miracle that any show is successful and the only reason shows are successful is because of teamwork and a shared belief in the importance of the production. Your team is your family and like all families you will have disagreements and fights but if you build and maintain trust within the team you can overcome any adversity and transform obstacles into opportunities.

The first week of any collaborative process should be dedicated to building trust and creating a team. Relationships are built on shared experiences, achieving success, and recognizing each other's strengths. So you will need to use your time to structure activities and projects designed to encourage meaningful interactions, allow people to collaborate and successfully create something, and above all understand and recognize each individual's strengths.

In any endeavor each individual's contribution is important. My father was a football coach and he once told me that "every play is designed to to score, but it takes everyone doing their job to make it happen and that is why it is so difficult." Everyone in the production also needs to know their job, how to do it, believe in themselves, believe in each other, and work together to reach the goal, otherwise the whole thing falls apart. You also have to create a culture where people are encouraged to take creative risks and understand that failure is not fatal. When something fails in rehearsal we learn, correct, and try again. You never fail, you learn and you grow. Success is always more meaningful when paired with growth.

Work on having your team put their egos aside and take the time to appreciate each person on the team. Remember that the deck is stacked against you and the only weapons you have to win, are the people you create with. Create for each other. Create to prove the world wrong. Create a family.

Team Building Activities

High Fives

Exercise

- Begin by having the class move throughout the space for about thirty seconds to one minute so that the group feels comfortable navigating the space without collisions.
- Next, have each member of the class hold up one hand and continue moving throughout the space, but each time they make eye contact with someone in the group they must give each other a high five and say "hey!" in an enthusiastic way.

Purpose

- This activity forces the group to acknowledge each other and interact in a positive way. When someone looks at you and gets excited and you are met with an enthusiastic high five you immediately feel accepted and you get a small confidence boost. You will notice within thirty seconds how the energy in the room shifts and how forced smiles that occurred in the beginning of the activity will turn into genuine smiles of happiness.

Name Game

Exercise

- Have everyone in the group gather into a circle.
- Have each member of the group introduce themselves by saying his/her name and offer a few interesting facts about themselves.
- Create a movement/dance move based on one interesting fact and perform this move while saying the student's name.
- Have everyone in the group repeat the movement and name several times.
- Repeat with each member of the group.

Purpose

- This activity allows the group to learn each other's names quickly by connecting the name to a physical movement while also providing information that can help students connect through shared interests or experiences.

Ground Rules

Exercise

- Break the class up into pairs of two and have each pair create four rules that they feel the class should follow throughout the semester/camp. Some examples include: Treat others with respect, no favoritism, etc.
- Once each pair has agreed on the rules have them merge with another group and form a group of four. Each group must share the rules each have created and select only four to agree on together. This will narrow the rules from eight to four.
- Once each group of four has agreed on which four rules they feel should be adopted by the group, have two groups of four merge into a group of eight. In this new group each previous group must share the rules each have created and select only four to agree on together. This will narrow the rules from eight to four.
- Once each group of eight has agreed on which four rules they feel should be adopted by the group, have two groups of eight merge into a group of sixteen. In this new group each previous group must share the rules each have created and select only four to agree on together. This will narrow the rules from eight to four.
- Repeat this process until the class is back together forming one large group. Decide which four rules will be adopted by the group and then write the rules down.

Purpose

- This exercise provides many wonderful outcomes. Each student is allowed to contribute rules and ideas that address fears they carried into the group. Each student also must listen and collaborate with other members of the group to agree on rules that address both students' needs. This allows the student to feel confident speaking up for his/her needs, understand compromise and think about the overall needs of the group. This also secretly has the students create their own culture of respect and trust while verbally creating the culture of respect and trust.

Spotlight

Exercise

- Place a chair in the front of the room.
- Have each member of the class or group sit and face the chair.
- One at a time, have each member of the class come up to the chair and sit down and let the audience look at them for one minute.
- In order to pass the time the student is allowed to answer one of the following questions. This question is selected by the instructor and the student receives only one question. The student is not required to talk, the question is there to help the student take their mind off of being stared at for a period of time. The point of the exercise is to gain experience being themselves in front of a group and allowing the group to see them, not to answer a question or entertain the group.
- Questions
 - What are your dreams?
 - What is the most embarrassing thing that has ever happened to you?
 - Who is your hero and why?
 - If you could go back in time and relive any day of your life to experience it again, what would it be? Why?
 - What gives you strength and what is your greatest fear?
 - What was the happiest day of your life? What was the worst day of your life?
 - What was an obstacle you were forced to overcome?
 - What was the time you were your most vulnerable?
 - What was a time you helped someone and a time that you betrayed someone?
 - If you could go back in time and change one thing in your life what would it be?
 - What was a time you felt helpless and a time you were on top of the world?

- What would your best friend say about you? What would your worst enemy say?
- What do you hope to be and what do you hope you never become?
- Once the minute has passed the student is thanked and the next member of the class goes to the spotlight.
- Once everyone in the group has participated, gather the group into a circle to discuss the experience.

Purpose

- This is without question one of, if not the best team building exercise I have ever witnessed. The activity not only provides the experience of being the center of attention, it forces the student to confront the most terrifying aspects of stage fright by having them be the center of attention while also being unprepared. The student is then offered the ability to escape the uncomfortable situation by sharing an experience in his/her life that is true. Great acting requires truth and you will never be able to connect truthfully to a character or another human being if you cannot be comfortable being vulnerable in front of a group and connecting to a true part of yourself. Being vulnerable is what makes us human, yet human beings are so uncomfortable admitting weakness that we pay actors to be vulnerable in front of us so that we do not feel alone. Once a fear is confronted and conquered, acceleration can occur.
- There is another magical quality about this exercise. All friendships and meaningful relationships occur when we allow ourselves to be vulnerable with another person and share something true about ourselves that asks the other individual not to judge us. When the other person listens, does not judge, and shares something in return we have a strong foundation on which to build the relationship.
- In the discussion, you will find that people feel more connected with each other and that people will share how they now feel bonded with others who share the same struggles.

Statues

Exercise

- Begin by having the class move throughout the space. Once they are able to establish a flow where they can navigate the space safely announce that you will yell out an object or profession and each person must immediately freeze into a statue of whatever comes to mind as soon as they hear what was yelled out.
- The choices can and should vary based on each individual's life experiences. In the beginning, you will see small and safe choices. Remember to emphasize "going big" and taking risks.
- Examples: Pirate, Cowboy, Opera Singer, Dancer, Wrestler, Soldier, Parent, Teacher, Super Hero, Dinosaur, etc.

Purpose

- This exercise allows the students to build off of the skills and knowledge gained from contact improvisation and has them use big movements to create a larger than life character. This exercise also teaches students to follow their impulses and commit to creative choices.

Walking on Different Surfaces While in Character

Exercise

- Have the class move throughout the space and introduce new surfaces for them to walk on just as in the previous exercise. However this time have them create a character to inhabit the world where this environment exists.
- Example: If the surface is ice, the student could possibly be a polar bear, a penguin, abominable snowman, explorer, or any character his/her imagination creates.

Purpose

- This activity is building on the skills created throughout the previous lessons and is combining them and tying them into storytelling. This exercise also introduces character development and motivation or objective.

Creating Characters and Having Them Interact

Exercise

- Have the class move throughout the space. You as the instructor will call out a character trait or profession, similar to the statues exercise, except in this exercise students will greet the next person they run into as these characters.
- Examples: Best friends, Cowboys in a showdown, Celebrities fighting over media attention, etc.

Purpose

- This builds upon the lessons of the previous exercise and moves the character development out of the self and into the acting partner in order to create a deeper, more complex, and ultimately more fun world.

Safari

Exercise

- Have everyone in the class vote on a location to have an adventure. This can be a real location like the moon or a fictional location like Hogwarts, Middle Earth, or Pandora.
- As the instructor create a fictional character that will serve as the Safari Guide throughout the adventure.
- Example: Under the Sea. As the instructor I create a Australian Safari Guide and address the group. (Note: The class will act out each element that the Safari Guide is narrating) Safari Guide: "Alright Class are you ready to go on an adventure? Well no you are not because I can see you haven't got your safari packs with you. Well...go get them. Hurry, hurry put them on. Let me see, ah yes looking good. Now everyone step into the submarine that will take us under the sea. Can you open the hatch? Good everyone in. Is everyone in? Lets close the hatch to keep us safe. Please push that red button and we will be on our way. (Begin to shake) Whoaaaaaaa and now we are off. As you can see we are going deeper and deeper. Oh no there is a large squid that thinks we are its food! Quick someone grab the steering wheel and get us away! Turn Left! Turn Right! You push the big button that says do not push! Just do it!! Whoaaaaaaa we are going so fast we are out of reach. Quick someone pull the emergency anchor! Whoooooooooo. Is everyone alright? That was close. Oh wow everyone look outside it is a sunken ship. Maybe it has treasure. Want to go check it out? I bet you do. Grab your safari packs and inside you will find your scuba suits. Put them on. Quickly! Alright let's head out through the hatch. Alright is everyone out? Lets go explore. Everyone come here. Let's be very careful moving through the ship because sometimes these old ships fall on you. Let's go into this first room. Everyone in your safari pack you will find your flash lights and anything else you will need. Let's look around. Everyone gather round do you see that treasure chest? Let's open it. Who can open it? Nice! Look at all that money! Everyone grab some and put it in your pack. Shhhhhhhh! Do you hear that? It sounds like Sharks!!! Swim away! Grab out your harpoons! Fire! I think we scared them off. Oh no look at our ship! It is damaged! What are we gonna do? Wait do you see that above us? Dolphins!! Everyone grab a lasso out of your pack. Swing it and catch a dolphin. Lets ride it back home. Yeeehawwwwwww! Alright we are back on shore let's gather up. Is anyone injured? Good.
- Following this adventure bring everyone into a circle to discuss the experience.

Purpose

- Acting begins in the imagination. If you cannot imagine it, it cannot happen. This exercise forces its participants to immerse themselves into their active imaginations and commit to inhabiting a collective imaginary world. The exercise builds upon each previous exercise and culminates in a fun interactive experience that allows everyone to explore a world in which they have never been.

Mirror Exercises

Exercise

- Break the class up into pairs of two and have each pair face each other and make eye contact.
- Have the pair decide which one is Partner 1 and which one is Partner 2.
- Have Partner 1 be the mirrored image of Partner 2 and mimic every movement in unison with Partner 2. This goal is to move so well together that an outside observer would not be able to distinguish which partner is leading and which is following. Make sure that the partner leading the exercise is moving slowly and the goal of both partners should be to move in perfect unison.
- Once the pair move well together, have the leader switch and now Partner 2 is the mirror image of Partner 1.

- Once both parties have gone, sit down as a group and discuss the experience.

Purpose

- This exercise is about connection and responding more to your partner than to your ideas. When you are able to make your partner the most important person in your world the exercise is successful.

Interviews

Exercise

- Break the class up into pairs of two and have each pair interview each other and find 3 things they have in common. Give them 3 minutes to complete this exercise that they do not have in common, but that they find fascinating and wonderful.
- Keep repeating the exercise until everyone in the group has partnered up with each other.
- Have each person share what they learned about their team members.

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1.2: Develop An Idea or Concept for your Story

Ideas can come from anywhere and the beauty of having a group is that each of you see the world through a different lens and each of you will be drawn to different objects, themes, and ideas. When deciding on ideas you must first establish a strong community before you begin selecting ideas or making choices. When someone brings an idea forward to the group make sure that the gift is acknowledged and appreciated. It takes a tremendous amount of courage for people to bring their ideas forward especially if that idea is going to be evaluated or criticized. Make sure each member's ideas are welcomed and then discuss the creative possibilities of the idea. Then as a group select the idea that excites the group as a whole and provides the most dramatic possibilities.

One philosophy to live by is to “be willing to give up your good ideas.” When your idea is not selected it does not mean that the idea itself is bad or that the group does not like you, it just means that idea will fit a different group or time and be better served later. Instead help the group refine the collective idea. You are brilliant and are full of good ideas, let them come and trust that more will come later. Do not stay married to an idea, rather be open to change and help make your friend's ideas come to life.

When selecting ideas first have each idea be presented to the group by the person who is bringing it in. This will allow the idea to be introduced to the group by its most passionate representative, and then open the idea to questions. Make sure the questions are positive and are designed to see where the idea can go dramatically. Once the idea is presented then move to the next until all ideas have been brought forward.

Next write the ideas on the board and give everyone 2 votes meaning that they can vote to select 2 items. Go through each item and tally up the results. Erase the ideas with the lowest votes and repeat the process giving each person only 1 vote. Continue until you have 2-3 ideas and then select the idea with the highest votes.

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1.3: Collaborating on a Theme

A theme is an idea, a simple, clear, and powerful idea. Every story you have ever been told was created to teach you something. The more powerful and life changing the lesson, the more sacred the story. Human beings are incredible entities that extract meaning from stories that are not true. It is this ability that has allowed the arts and creativity to thrive. If your story has no theme then it has no lesson and will leave your audience's minds faster than it entered. If you are going to spend months or years of your life on a story shouldn't it be important? Human beings not only extract lessons from stories, but often base our existence on them.

The theme is the heartbeat/ soul/ central message of the story. The theme is power statement in which the entire imaginary world of the play was created in order to deliver. The theme is vital because it will help guide how you develop the characters and their objectives and will also guide how the production is presented. Each character will have a relationship to this theme and this will determine his/her actions. Think of the theme as the glue or force that connects all of the souls that both view and present the production. When starting a play and identifying your theme ask yourself why do you need to tell the story? Why should the audience watch? What makes this story special? Once you have written these ideas down see if you can summarize or synthesize it in one sentence.

Have the group write down themes that would be worth writing a play about. Ask them to write out the inspirational sentence, then see if it can be simplified or refined. Repeat until each person has 3-4 themes. Have them choose the most powerful and present it to the group.

Once again make sure that each member of the group presents their idea for the theme and make sure to write the theme on a visible space for all of the group to see. Once the idea is presented then move to the next until all ideas have been brought forward.

Next write the ideas on the board and give everyone 2 votes meaning that they can vote to select 2 items. Go through each item and tally up the results. Erase the ideas with the lowest votes and repeat the process giving each person only 1 vote. Continue until you have 2-3 ideas and then select the idea with the highest votes.

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1.4: Deciding on a Setting

The setting is the environment in which the conflict can take place. The conflict and setting will also contribute to the action (or things that happen) on stage. You can set your play in any location you choose and as many locations as you would like. You can have a single location or multiple locations however, there are pros and cons to each.

When creating a play imagine that the life of the character is continuous and the play takes place on the most important day or set of days in this character's life. Now you cannot stage the continuous life of this character uninterrupted because it would take too long, so you are choosing to show us the most important parts, of the most important day. Because you are selecting the most important events that happened on this day, all essential conflicts and actions should happen on stage. You want to make sure that the audience gets to be present for the major events, this will engage them more and allow them to feel as though they are part of the play.

In the beginning of your process, you can choose any location you want and your ideas will come from the combination of Location + Setting + Theme. Explore and choose a setting or world that would be fun to explore. Use the same selection process as before. Choose a general location first and know that as the idea progresses you can add additional settings if needed.

Single Location

If you choose to set your play in a single location your play will be easier to produce and will be more accessible to theater companies later. Having your play in one location also allows your set to be detailed and specific. Your designer is only working on one location so the designer can focus on specifics. The catch is that you have to choose a location where multiple characters would logically meet and engage in the story and conflict. If, for instance, you have set your play at a school, you may want to choose a location at the school that everyone would use like a courtyard or cafeteria rather than a classroom because you will create an opportunity to introduce more characters. Setting your play in one location can be difficult, but if it is possible, try to achieve it.

Multiple Locations

If you choose to set your play in multiple locations then you are only limited by your imagination. You are free to take your audience to any location you choose at any moment, free from limitations. The drawback to this is that the more locations you choose to add into your play, the more money it will cost to produce it which can limit your accessibility, and the set design for each location will be less detailed than if you set it at one location. I have done plays with over 50 locations and some locations had to be suggested through lighting and sound only. Do not limit your creativity. Write your play the way you want, it is your play.

Process

Have each person present a location or world that they would like to set a play in. Have each idea be presented to the group by the person who is bringing it in. This will allow the idea to be introduced to the group by its most passionate representative, and then open the idea to questions. Make sure the questions are positive and are designed to see where the idea can go dramatically. Once the idea is presented then move to the next until all ideas have been brought forward.

Next write the ideas on the board and give everyone 2 votes meaning that they can vote to select 2 items. Go through each item and tally up the results. Erase the ideas with the lowest votes and repeat the process giving each person only 1 vote. Continue until you have 2-3 ideas and then select the idea with the highest votes.

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1.5: Creating a Conflict

Conflict is the primary ingredient of drama and without it drama ceases to exist. Conflict is when two opposing forces collide. David and Goliath, Harry Potter and Voldemort, You and Your Future are all examples of opposing forces and these forces meet within the battlefield of story. Stories were invented to help us make sense of the world and find our place in it, and the world is full of conflict. Stories are how our ancestors taught the children in the tribe how to hunt, gather, be part of the community and find their way in life. The power of story still resonates with us today. We all have goals and needs and must navigate obstacles in order to achieve them. In fact you cannot exist without encountering conflict constantly throughout your day. In stories, the greater the conflict and the more impossible the obstacle, the more legendary the hero's journey is to its audience.

Conflict is the element that holds the audience's attention throughout the play. The audience came to see someone deal with a problem. The conflict should build continuously throughout the play and create urgency with the characters involved. As an audience member you get to escape your reality and problems and witness another person's struggle in order to gain perspective on your current or future situations. It is for this reason that you must make sure that your conflict builds in intensity and reaches a satisfying conclusion.

As soon as the conflict is resolved your audience will begin disengaging from your story and reentering their own lives. This is often a problem for new writers who create a conflict and then quickly resolve it thus terminating the audience's attention. It is possible to layer obstacles so that the audience stays engaged but you need to have a primary conflict for your story. Next you can have a series of smaller conflicts or obstacles that build tension as the story progresses, however you **MUST** introduce the next obstacle prior to the conclusion of the current obstacle. For example, if your main character needs to get to Las Vegas. Once they get to Las Vegas the audience feels that they have now completed the journey and will be furious if you introduce the new obstacle of getting to Denver once the characters have landed. Instead it is much more effective to have the characters discover while in flight that the venue they are traveling to or person they are pursuing has transferred to Denver, and they must adjust their plans. You have to stay ahead of your audience, if your audience knows what your characters are going to do, before they do it, your audience will be bored and you will lose them.

Conflict can take many forms, but is primarily broken into two main categories and each has several subcategories. The categories are as follows:

Internal

(Human vs. Self)

Mental

Emotional/Spiritual

Physical

External

(Human vs. Something Outside of Themselves)

Human Vs. Human

Human Vs. Nature

Human Vs. Supernatural

Human Vs. Society

Human Vs. Science

Process

List all of the types of conflict on the board. Vote as a group on the primary conflict of the story and then if it is external choose and internal conflict that the Hero must also overcome in order to gain the skill necessary to overcome the primary external conflict. Make sure discuss ideas as a group as to where each idea can go dramatically.

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1.6: Developing Characters

Creating original characters is one of the most fun and rewarding experiences you will have as an artist. You are bringing something into being through your imagination and audience members will live and see the world through this character's eyes and experiences and often this fictional character will make a lasting impact on actual people's lives.

When creating characters, you want to make sure that each individual in your play has a direct tie to the conflict and theme of your story. If for example your conflict or story centers around a plane crashing or disappearing, you want to start by creating the character by its relationship to the event: "I am the captain of the plane that crashed" "I am the widow of a passenger on the plane that crashed" "I am the flight controller that last spoke to the pilot of the plane that crashed" etc.

This allows you to start with a character directly tied to the event and therefore logically connected to your play. This character is not defined by gender, name, personality, etc. at this point. Once you have created enough characters from this exercise you can begin giving them an identity.

There are many ways you can explore and develop character's identities. You can ask actors to improvise a backstory and interview the character. You can go to a public place and base a character off of people you observe. You can base a character off of a friend or acquaintance. Or you can simply use your imagination and create the character from your head.

One primary component that a character must possess is a strong need or desire or goal that drives their actions and is tied directly to the conflict of the play. Character is all action and character is found and defined for the audience in the character's actions and how the character pursues their objective or goal. Make sure that each character in your play has a strong and identifiable need and allow that to guide the actions they take throughout the story.

Once you have the idea or conflict you then create a person based on their relationship to the idea or conflict. State the character existence as "I am the (Relationship) to/from the (Idea / Conflict)."

An example of this would be if your play were based on a conflict centered around an inheritance you would create a character with a phrase like: "I am the favorite child of the person who is bestowing the inheritance." or "I am the corrupt lawyer in charge of arbitrating the inheritance."

Have each person write down the characters that they create and place them around the room and have everyone walk around the room and look at the ideas as though they were art exhibits at a museum. Once everyone has had a chance to see every idea select 10-20 that stand out. Then decide which characters you would like to have in your play.

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1.7: Assigning Archetypes

One of the most insightful and captivating histories on storytelling is Joseph Campbell's The Hero with a Thousand Faces. In the book, he outlines how all myths and stories are analogies of the human experience and how each character and story archetype have counterparts to your life. The enduring quality of a myth is in its ability to teach and inspire the listener. There are many character and story archetypes yet each story has 5 essential archetypes. In some cases, one character can be the vessel for several of the following types, yet these archetypes are always present in stories. The following are an amalgamation of many theories, yet the more you study story structure you will notice how each theory and perspective has many commonalities with its counterparts. The following is my attempt to combine them.

The Hero

The hero is your lead character and the character that the audience is meant to identify with and the character is a representation of the audience member. The hero can be any gender, race, species, etc. but each hero must possess several qualities in order to be effective.

Hero Trait 1: A Hero Must Have a Good Heart

A hero or antihero must deep down have a good heart. Even and especially when the character has a jaded past and has been damaged by the world, it is vital that the audience understand and see the hero as good. The audience must see themselves as the character in order to be invested in the story and each person always feels they are good or tries to have good intentions. This is why villains in history have been so scary, because each believed that they were doing just and good things by committing atrocities. Your character does not need to be overly good and can be a bad person most of the time, but you need to have at least one small moment where their inner goodness can be displayed.

Hero Trait 2: A Hero Must Know They are Special, But Not Know Why.

At the beginning of the journey, the hero must know deep down that they are special and were meant to achieve a greater purpose. The problem that the character faces is that they do not know what that purpose is. In their current situation they do not see how they will ever be able to escape and discover who they are, let alone achieve something. The journey of your story is what will make the character's purpose clear, but at the beginning the audience needs to see the character's drive.

In class, I always ask my students to raise their hand if they think they are special. Most of the time only a few do. I then ask, "Why did you not raise your hand? Is it because you truly do not believe you are special?" The truth is all people believe they are special and have big dreams, before life kicks them in the teeth. However, you would not have showed up to school, or work, or be reading this book if you did believe you had something to give to the world. Often we try to hide what our special qualities are and avoid voicing our dreams in order to avoid ridicule, but those desires are there in all humans. Each of us feels we have something to give and this has been the case since humans began telling stories. When we need inspiration we look to the stories we were told growing up, when we are broken we look to those heroes who overcame obstacles far scarier than our own. If your audience needs to see themselves in your hero then you need to make sure that this consistent human experience is part of your character's traits.

Hero Trait 3: The Hero Must Be The Chosen One

Only the hero can defeat the villain. The hero is the chosen one and with that power and responsibility the hero must fight their own battles. Can you imagine a story where you invested your time and love following a hero you thought to be the chosen one and in the end it was someone else and they were irrelevant? You would be furious! I am sure that the writers who did this in the past patted themselves on the back and felt superior to their audience, but that victory was short lived when that story was quickly forgotten. If you spent 8 Harry Potter books to find out that Neville Longbottom was the actual hero you would never pick up the books again. You invested and identified with the hero, it is your job to tell us how the hero defeats the villain. Now the hero does not need to win, but the hero had better go down trying because that is the human spirit and that will inspire us to keep going on our hero's journey.

In life, you will have your villains that you will need to overcome. These villains will be your villains and your villains alone. If you are going to be an adult and achieve your greatness you will need to overcome your villains. Sometimes the villain is yourself, sometimes it is a struggle only you have, and heroes fight their battles and victims ask others to fight their battles for them. You are the hero in your life and this characteristic is central to the themes and lessons all stories have shared since humans began telling stories.

Hero Trait 4: A Hero Needs a Flaw

The flaw is an internal obstacle that must be overcome in order to defeat the villain. Often the hero and the villain share this flaw and are examples of how the flaw can shape your destiny and actions. In a true hero's journey the hero has to grow and mature as the story progresses. The character is following the same structure our lives follow, but in a condensed timeline. Every human being has flaws and internal battles needed to be overcome in order to progress towards our goals, this needs to be present with the main character in the story.

Hero Trait 5: A Hero Needs to Have a Straightforward and Urgent Goal

Aaron Sorkin and William Goldman refer to this as the intention, others refer to it as a goal or need, others refer to it as the super objective. What matters is that the Hero has a goal/desire/intention that helps drive them through the plot and motivates them to keep going. Each scene and the play as a whole are an attempt to achieve this goal for the character. This is connected to characteristic 2 and this goal/need/intention will serve as the character's boon (or Prize) at the end of the journey or will be the character's downfall.

The Villain

The Villain is the antagonist of the story and will come in any form needed and derived from the conflict. In an internal conflict the Villain and the Hero are one and the same. In external conflict the Villain can be nature, another human, a society, supernatural entity, or scientific construction. What matters is the Villain is the primary obstacle in the way of the Hero achieving their goal. The Villain also has characteristics shared throughout all stories.

Villain Trait 1: The Villain Hates the Hero

The Villain often hates the hero for no other reason than that they are good. The Villain sees the Hero as a threat and because of this, tries to destroy the Hero only to find that in doing so it has prepared the Hero with the skills to overcome the Villain in the final confrontation.

Villain Trait 2: The Villain Wants to Possess or Destroy the Heroine/Goal/McGuffin

The Villain is the antagonist of the story because it seeks to possess or destroy something of great importance to the world of the Hero. The Villain is singular in its pursuit of the Heroine/Goal/McGuffin and possess such a threat to the world of the story that the audience is compelled to root for the hero.

Villain Trait 3: The Less We Know About the Villain the Better

The audience does not need nor do they care about the Villain's backstory. They are content with the knowledge that the Villain is evil. The more backstory you give to your Villain the more sympathetic you make them and you risk the audience identifying more with your Villain than your Hero. You want the villain to seem scary, powerful, and invincible so that the audience learns the lessons of self development and courage the journey is reinforcing. Neil Gaiman said "Stories are important not because they teach us that dragons are real, but that dragons can be defeated." Remember that the villain represents intense struggles we, as the audience, will encounter in our lives and it is important to have us identify with the Hero more than the trail we will later face.

Villain Trait 4: The Villain Has to Destroy Something Precious or Do Something Truly Terrible to Solidify the Audiences' Hatred.

Even though the audience will be content with the knowledge that the Villain is evil, you will need to have the Villain do something truly terrible to reinforce the audience's hatred of the villain. The action the Villain takes will also serve as a defining moment for the Hero where failure to defeat the Villain no longer becomes an option and the final confrontation must happen. The more the audience hates the Villain the more they will root for the Hero.

One of the best speeches concerning stories that I can remember comes from the film Lord of the Rings: The Two Towers. Towards the end of the film, the hero and his sidekick are exhausted and running from both humans and monsters that have tried to kill them. The Hero looks around in the middle of a battle and sees the carnage all being caused because of his journey. He sits down in the middle of the battlefield and decides to give up. His sidekick sits down next to him and says "It's like in the old stories, the ones that really mattered. The heroes were fighting against villains that were so powerful you thought that there was no way they could win. But they kept going and in the end they did win. Those are the stories that stuck with us. Those are the stories worth telling."

The Heroine/Goal/McGuffin/Stakes

This archetype goes by many names, but is crucial for the plot. The Heroine/ Goal/ McGuffin/ Stakes is the noun (person, place, or thing) that the characters are fighting to protect. What are all of the characters fighting to save or protect? This could be a house, legacy, the world, a person, a document, etc. Each character cares about this noun and it is the driving force behind the conflict. You must be able to clearly identify it or you will need to raise the stakes of your story. If the characters do not know what they are fighting for, neither will your audience and you will lose them. Ask yourself what is the conflict over? What are the characters fighting to save?

This ties to your real life in that each of us has unique things we treasure and strive to protect. The conflicts in your life that will shape you will have this treasured item at stake and these stories help to prepare us both in strategy and experience for the trials to come.

The Sidekick

The sidekick is the friend or helper on the hero's journey. The sidekick helps the Hero overcome the Villain and saves the Hero at least once on the journey. The Sidekick is brave, loyal, and has all of the characteristics of the hero except one. The Sidekick is not the chosen one. However, the Hero can only defeat the Villain with the help of the Sidekick, but the Sidekick would lose if ever to encounter the Villain alone.

The Sidekick is a representation of the friends we encounter on our life's journey. As a Hero you are going to face Villains that only you can defeat and save things that you care about. In your journey, you can defeat any Villain you encounter, and achieve any goal you set, but all stories teach us that you can never accomplish anything alone. You will need friends. You will need friends who help shape you into the Hero you will become and also pick you up when the world has crushed you. However, your Villains are your Villains and your Villains alone. Your friends cannot fight your battles for you, merely support you in your endeavor, for they have their own Villains in their personal stories they must defeat.

The Mentor

The Mentor is the Teacher in the story. The Mentor helps the Hero unlock their true potential. The Mentor does not fully train or prepare the Hero for the Villain, because the journey does that. The Mentor's purpose is to help the Hero discover their potential so that it can be developed. Once the Hero's potential has been unlocked, the Mentor will encounter a barrier that it cannot cross. In some stories, the teacher cannot leave the school, a trainer cannot enter the ring, in religion God cannot come down from the heavens, and in some stories the mentor dies. The barrier is important because if the Hero has a Mentor that is more powerful than themselves, then there is no reason to step up and become the Hero. The Mentor is removed from the story so that the Hero has no one to hide behind and no choice but to step up to the Hero's challenges.

The Mentor of the story represents the influential adults in our lives that help prepare us for the obstacles ahead. In life, your teachers do not follow you outside of school, your parents will kick you out of the nest or will eventually die, and you must step up and become the guiding force in your own life. You will take the lessons you garnered from them and use them as you navigate your path, but each story attempts to prepare you for this step along the way.

The Process

Once you have created characters for your play, you need to decide how many characters your play should have. You can choose any number, but once you have come to a decision you need to select which characters to fill that number.

Once the characters have been chosen it is time to step back and look at your decisions thus far. You should have selected a Theme, Conflict, Setting, and the Characters that will be in the show. Now based on those choices, which character best fits the Theme and conflict to be your hero for the journey of your play? Once selected, then look at the Theme, Conflict, and Setting and select a character that best fits the antagonist role of your story and can serve as the representation of the conflict of your story. Once you select your stories Hero and Villain the rest will fall into place. In order to do this with the group you will need to write each archetype down and go through the voting process to narrow down the decisions. Decide what is at stake in the conflict or what is your Heroine. Then decide on the mentor character. The rest will be sidekick roles and aid the Hero or Villain in the journey ahead.

Actor Improvisation

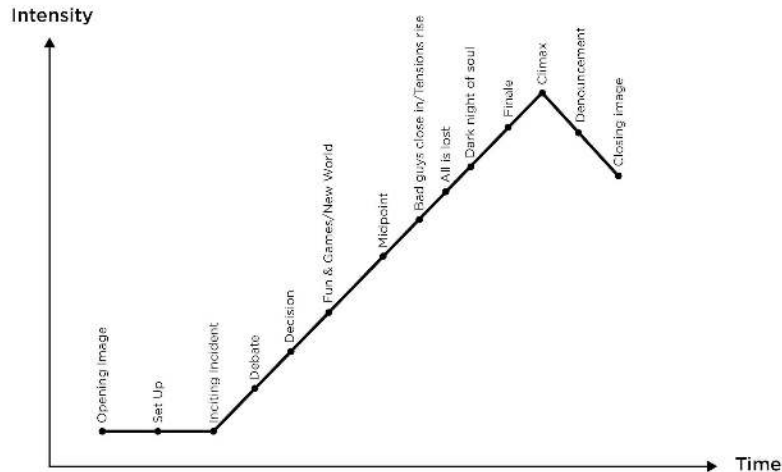
- Create a list of characters and then invite actors to choose a character to inhabit or portray.

- Ask the actor to introduce the character to you and to begin by using elements of their real life and somewhere in the middle of the interview or introduction begin blending character information with the actors backstory. This allows you to have a backstory and origin of the character based on reality.
- Once the actor has introduced the character and talked for a few minutes. Interview them and ask questions. Write down phrases and facts that stand out.
- Use the notes you have to flesh out the rest of the character and repeat the process with other characters.
- With the decided characters have class pair up in groups of 3 and create a vignette of how these 3 lives would interact and what scenario they would be in.
- Select the characters that you find would support your story or produce the most dramatic possibility and begin writing a scene with them.

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1.8: Structuring the Plot

Plot is just another name for Story. Plot is the series of events that are structured to take the hero on a transformative journey throughout the story. Stories have been around for centuries and throughout that time the structure of storytelling has become solidified and with that there are essential components or rules you must follow. There are always attempts to break the form and some are done quite well, but if you just follow the structure and deliver a strong and well crafted story your audience will be receptive and happy. Each plot or story has essential components and below I will briefly outline them. You can choose to devise a cohesive story around one character's journey or connect a series of scenes around a theme.



Opening Image

Every single story is about a transformation. Blake Snyder describes this beautifully in his book [Save the Cat](#). He says “Every play is about the transformation of a caterpillar into a butterfly.” Every story is also a hero's journey. We are introduced to a hero who, like us, is trapped in circumstances they cannot control. Yet this hero has a goal and in order to achieve that goal they will be met with many obstacles. It is watching this character overcome the obstacles that transforms not only the hero but the audience. The opening image is where the story shows us the main character in the beginning or caterpillar stage of their journey. This is important because the opening image and final image are the things your audience will remember the most. It is the contrast of these two images that tell the story.

Setup/Prologue/Exposition

Every story has to have certain elements in the beginning in order for your audience to understand and follow the plot. In the set up you have to establish the setting or time and location, introduce the main characters, set up the rules of the world, and establish what a normal day is like in the main characters world.

Establish the Setting:

The audience needs to understand where and when the play is taking place. Remember that in a play the action and story is being conveyed through dialogue and will need to be clearly established up front. You even do this when telling a quick story to your friend: “Last I was walking into Wal-Mart and _____”

or in a joke: “2 guys walk into a bar.”

or in a Fairy Tale: “Once upon a time in a land far far away...”

In each instance, the Setting is established up front so the audience has a location in which to stage the rest of the story.

Introducing the Main Characters:

Within the first few pages of the story the audience needs to be introduced to the main characters they will be following for the journey of the play. The audience needs to know who to care about and identify with. If you want the audience to bond with your

character, it helps to have the protagonist do a small act of kindness to allow us to see the characters potential as a hero. The audience does not need backstory, but they do need to be aware of the principal players in the world of the story.

If this is a love story, the audience needs to see a selfish and childish hero who avoids responsibility and only strives to have fun. We then need to see the over responsible counterpart that is overstressed, overworked, and avoids fun and risk at all cost. These characters behavior, flaws, and routines need to be established so that when they meet in the inciting incident, the audience understands the journey each character needs to undertake.

Setting Up the Rules of the World:

Every story takes place in an alternate reality and each reality has a set of rules that the characters must abide by. If your characters are in a world where ghosts or magic exists, you must establish this early so that when these elements are explored later the audience is with you. You have to clearly establish these rules early so that they can be used later in the story.

Even in situations where the story seems realistic there are rules. For example, every romance has the rule or convention that “love at first sight” exists as well as the rule/convention/concept of the existence of a “true love.” In a story the author needs the audience to root for the leads to get together and since the author is limited to a two hour narrative the easiest way to establish a strong connection is to create the existence of “Love at First Sight.” This rule is not realistic because the only human beings that truly believe in love at first sight are stalkers, but the convention or rule allows the author to establish a connection between the main characters and then use the rest of the time to focus on the plot elements that help tell the actual story.

The concept of “True Love” is also useful and equally counter to real life. The rule of true loves existence allows for the audience to understand that the main characters share a special bond and connection that is worth enduring the trials of the story. In real life, human beings have complicated relationships with everything. Do you love your parents? Do you love your spouse or significant other? Do you love your children? Do you love food? Now do you love all of those things the same way? NO!! That is both disgusting and illegal, but you cannot say that your love for any of those things is less ‘true’ than the other. Nevertheless the concept of a true love allows the author to establish a worthy connection between the characters and convinces the audience to root for the characters to get together.

Establishing Normal:

For the purpose of telling your story, you need to establish what the rules of the imaginary world you are creating are and then show us what a normal and average day in this world, with these rules, looks like. It is very important to do this because when you introduce the conflict it will disrupt the normal flow of the world and both the characters and the audience will see it. It is also important to note that the world of the exposition is not maintainable and if life were to continue this way for the character the characters would either die or live wasted and meaningless lives. Even if their life is filled with happiness, it is unfulfilled in ways they are not yet aware of and that is why the story is worth telling.

Catalyst/Inciting Incident

The inciting incident or catalyst is the thing that happens that causes everything else to happen. This is the event that will introduce the conflict of the story. This can be a character being introduced, an event occurring, or something as small as a letter being dropped off. This is the plot device that disrupts the normal life you have established and sets the plot in motion. Ultimately, this is where the problem is introduced that you are going to spend the rest of the story solving. While there are many points in the rising action and prologue/exposition, there is only one inciting incident.

Debate

Once the Catalyst or Inciting Incident has occurred, the Hero contemplates taking the journey to confront the problem. Most human beings never feel ready to take on a difficult task, let alone a life defining journey. This plot point is really important to have because it highlights a truly human characteristic. Every great hero does not go willingly at first to their destiny, they doubt themselves. This contemplation is usually a discussion with a friend or mentor, but can also be a soliloquy.

Decision

The Hero does not always make the decision to go on a journey to confront the problem. This is the plot point where the decision is made. The Hero either decides to confront the problem willingly or the villain/circumstances make a decision that forces the hero into action.

Fun and Games/New World

The main character begins the journey to confront the problem and this forces the character to enter a new world. The new world is the antithesis of the previous world and all of the rules from the previous world are broken. The section is called 'fun and games' by some writers but this does not necessarily mean that the world the character is entering is fun. The fun comes from the exploration of the world. Your main character is clueless to the rules of this world, as is your audience, and both will discover the world together. If for example the world of the exposition is safe and predictable, the hero must enter a world that is dangerous and unpredictable. This section is rather long and allows for new characters to be introduced. This is also why your hero is clueless at the beginning of the story, because as you introduce the new world to them the audience is equally clueless and you can hide any further exposition in dialogue or actions by the hero asking questions or discovering things on their own.

Midpoint

The midpoint of the play is where the main character has adequately explored the new world and has unlocked a piece of hidden potential. This event usually manifests itself into a 'false victory' or 'false defeat.' This means that the character has a minor confrontation with another character and through the confrontation learns a new skill. This confrontation can either be a victory or defeat, but it is labeled as 'false' because there is much more to learn and the final confrontation is yet to come. Immediately following the midpoint is the intermission.

Bad Guys Close In/Tensions Rise

Following the victory or defeat at the midpoint, the Antagonist becomes aware of the hero and adds pressure. If the hero is part of a team, the team begins to struggle and fall apart. Relationships that were strong in Act 1 now begin to fracture. In addition the hero begins to doubt their abilities, the process, and begins losing faith in themselves and their team.

All is Lost

This is a major defeat at the hands of the antagonist causing the team to completely fracture and in the process destroys the heroes confidence. This can be the perceived loss of the goal, a character dying, something being lost, etc. In life, each person is going to be hit with events that crush any semblance of what we thought we were. This plot point illustrates that in story form and has characters struggle with an equal loss. Due to this loss, all progress made feels lost and the final problem appears insurmountable.

Dark Night of the Soul

This is the part of the story where the Hero contemplates giving up and in some cases even ending their life. As the Hero decides whether or not to continue, he or she is offered guidance by a sidekick or mentor and through this conversation the hero finally understands the deeper meaning of the theme. At the end of the scene, the hero decides to meet the antagonist in a final confrontation. The parallel in life is that only once we hit rock bottom can we begin anew and if you build on the lessons you have learned along your journey you can become the unstoppable force you were looking for all along.

Finale

The finale is the strongest point of conflict where the hero and antagonist collide. The more the hero has struggled throughout the journey, the more the audience has anticipated this confrontation, so make sure to capitalize on this by increasing the heroes struggles leading up to this point. At this point, the protagonist and antagonist are equally matched and now the hero is armed with experience and an unwavering understanding of the theme of the story. The protagonist and antagonist collide and the finale should be designed to test both characters to their breaking points.

Climax

The climax is the highest point of tension. Tension is created when we are anticipating an event but it has yet to occur. This is the moment where you extend the anticipation of victory or defeat, because once the event occurs it becomes part of the resolution and the audience will begin the process of disengaging from the performance and reconnecting with their lives.

Denouement / Falling Action / Resolution

Denouement means to unravel or unknot. The plot has been building tension and tying knots in the audiences stomachs and denouement is where the story receives closure and the knots are untied. In the Denouement, the conflict is resolved, the hero is either victorious or fails, life returns to as normal as possible for the characters following the events of the plot, and the audience

begins to internalize the themes and knowledge gained from the story. This should not take too long, and do get 'precious' or sentimental with the subject matter.

Closing Image

This is our final moment or image of the character as the transformed butterfly. This image should be powerful and will be the image your audience will carry with them out of the theater.

The Process

As a group, select an inciting incident then select a climax. Once you know what starts your conflict and what you are building to, the rest of your process is creating events that logically build tension and take you from point A to point B in a clear progression. Have each member of the group present the ideas and then go through the voting process to narrow choices.

You can also break up the play into a series of scenes that all relate to a common theme and then structure them in a way that they follow a narrative arc.

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1.9: Dividing the Play into Scenes

Every story you tell will be creating a world where you present a problem and over the course of the story you solve it. In the process of solving the problem, the hero is transformed and through the character's journey the audience learns an important essential truth. However, in order to tell this story you need to first chart the course of events that will take place so that you can maximize the impact of your narrative.

First begin by establishing your Inciting Incident. Ask yourself "what happens that sets the play in motion?" Then ask yourself "What should be the climax or final event?" Once you have these two items figured out, you will know where your story truly begins and what you are building to. The story of your play is the journey from Inciting Incident to Climax.

Create an outline where you have your Inciting Incident on one end and the Climax on the other. If you are creating a full length play, then you will need roughly 7-10 scenes. Scene 1 is where you introduce the world of your play, the main characters, establish a normal day for the characters, and at the end of the scene introduce the conflict with the Inciting Incident. Your final scene is the final confrontation of Hero and Villain and the Denouement or falling action where things return to as normal as possible after the events of the play. All of the scenes between are the events that build in tension and lead to the inevitable climax.

Crafting your plot allows you to sidestep writer's block, troubleshoot problems in advance, and build tension throughout your story. When you know what needs to be accomplished in the scene you are able to write to that objective and since you have already established a strong intention for each character, once you set them in the scene they will move toward that objective and the scene will write itself. If you experience problems, you can take a break from writing the scene since you already know where the scene ends and you can begin writing a later scene and stay productive.

Example 1

- **Act 1/Scene 1: Exposition, Foreshadowing, Inciting Incident.**
 - Establish characters, basic relationships, dreams/goals
 - World of the play: Rules, Givens, Setting
 - Conflict is introduced
 - Inciting incident happens
- **Scene 2: Rising action step 1**
 - Relationships are further defined
 - New relationships begin to form based out of conflict
 - Conflict is furthered and additional obstacles are introduced
 - Introduction of additional characters
- **Scene 3: Rising action step 2**
 - Conflict is furthered
 - Relationships continue to develop
 - Protagonist is able to form an idea of how to overcome the obstacle
- **Scene 4: Rising Action step 3**
 - Stronger relationships begin to get stronger and the weak ones get weaker.
 - At least one obstacle is overcome
 - Conflict is furthered as dark twist is revealed
- **Act 2/ Scene 5: Rising Action step 4**
 - Relationships continue to develop stronger relationships are formed and weaker ones continue to deteriorate.
 - Protagonist is able to overcome multiple obstacles
 - Conflict is furthered as the Antagonist becomes aware of the threat.

- **Scene 6: Rising Action step 5**
 - Conflict is furthered as Antagonist introduces additional obstacles
 - Protagonist feels defeated
- **Scene 7: Rising Action step 6**
 - Relationships strengthen through character revelations
 - Turning point as protagonist decides to continue fighting
- **Scene 8: Climax and Denouement**
 - Conflict rises and reaches a climax as Protagonist and Antagonist collide.
 - Conflict is resolved

Example 2

Act 1

- **Scene 1: Setup/Catalyst**
 - Opening Image
 - Set up / Prologue / Exposition
 - Catalyst or Inciting Incident
- **Scene 2: Rising Action**
 - Debate
 - Decision
 - Fun and Games or New World is introduced.
- **Scene 3: Rising Action/Fun and Games**
 - New Characters are introduced.
 - New world explored and obstacle is introduced.
 - Stakes raise and conflict is furthered.
- **Scene 4: Rising Action/ Fun and Games**
 - New obstacles are introduced.
 - New world is explored.
 - Hero becomes aware of potential.
- **Scene 5: Midpoint**
 - An obstacle is overcome or almost overcome.
 - Hero unlocks potential.
 - Dark turn happens that raises the stakes for the hero.

Intermission

Act 2

- **Scene 1: Bad Guys Close In or Tensions Rise**
 - Villain becomes aware of Hero and begins to set additional obstacles.
 - Relationships begin to fracture.
- **Scene 2: All is Lost**
 - Hero receives crushing defeat and relationships are torn apart.

- **Scene 3: Dark night of the Soul**
 - Hero contemplates giving up the journey or ending their life.
 - Side character counsels Hero and reminds them of the lessons learned throughout the journey and tremendous cost of failure.
 - Hero finds strength in the interaction and from within and decides to confront the villain directly.
- **Scene 4: Finale**
 - Hero and Villain meet in final conflict.
 - Climax is reached.
- **Scene 5: Denouement or Resolution**
 - Conflict is resolved and things return to as normal as possible.
 - A new normal is established.

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1.10: The Collaborative Writing Process

Collaboration can be one of the most rewarding and also frustrating processes you will ever undertake. Make sure that everyone is on board with the ideas and try to make sure that each person has a voice in the process. The times when friction happens the most is when a member of the group overpowers other members and forces their ideas into the process rather than collaborating. This is where improv training will help you, the number one rule of improv is to say yes to other's contributions. Work on the scene together, if you wanted to write a play by yourself you could easily do that, you are working with people you like so you can create something together. Make sure to keep your ego in check and help each other to be better than you are on your own.

When you collaborate, break the group into teams and go over the structure of your story. Clearly outline the progression of events from Inciting Incident to Climax and then break up each event into its own scene. Assign members to a scene and go over which characters should be in the scene and what events need to happen within the scene before it is completed. You want the scene to be able to stand on its own and build to a climax.

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1.11: The First Read

When you initially complete your first draft of the show you will want to sit down with the group and read it out loud. It will more than likely make you physically ill. You always think that it won't, but it does. Characters will be inconsistent, the story will feel jumbled and it is very easy to lose heart. Trust your process and your team! You have already done the impossible. You created something that did not exist. Celebrate your achievement and refine the work.

Ask the group what worked. There are always elements that don't work but if your focus on those your show will not progress, your team will pull apart, and you will lose motivation. Look at the elements that did work and build off of that. What characters came through? Which characters do you want to develop more? Which events really worked and can you make them better? Then, ask how can we rewrite the other scenes to fit with what we created and want to keep? Make sure that the discussion is positive and do not let it drift into a realm of negativity.

Some plot points may need to be reworked, you may find that a small side character fits better in a different role. Adjust and begin rewriting. Your process is going to be revising, the reading it out loud the revising some more.

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1.12: Rewrites - Workshop through Readings with Performers

The majority of your process will be rewriting and revising scenes along the way. As a director, make sure that your narrative is staying consistent and trust that your actors will ask questions or bring up inconsistencies that are out of character within the script. If you find your hero painted into a corner, don't worry. If you don't know how to solve the problem, neither will your audience and you have the ability to surprise them.

When rewriting or analyzing a scene, ask yourself these questions.

1. Who wants what? From Whom? What happens if they don't get it?
2. Does the scene build to a climax and propel us into the next scene?
3. Can the scene stand on its own dramatically? If not, how can it?
4. Is the problem the character is trying to solve within the scene too easy to solve? If so, how can it be made more difficult?
5. Is anything being explained and if so how can it be shown to the audience rather than told?
6. Are there any parts of the scene that are not necessary to the story I am telling? If so, cut them.

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1.13: Rehearsals - Put it up in front of an Audience

Rehearsals are where the true development of your play takes place. In rehearsals, you will find that things that sounded great in a reading fall flat once on stage, or that elements that were vague in the writing play out better on stage when a director and actors can help them develop. All in all, you have to give your all to the performance and make it the best it can possibly be and then put it in front of an audience for judgement. Your goal is to create a great story, not to be praised. Use the audience reactions as a guide to see what resonates and what falls flat, then improve.

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1.14: Revise

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1.15: Complete the Project and move on to your next Play.

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